themselves and decided to surrender. Accordingly, Khwaja-i-Qazi was sent as the mediator.

Babur while mentioning the incident, takes immense pride and says, ‘Having pardoned their offences against ourselves, we went back to beleaguer Samarkand.’

Now, the real challenge for Babur was set to arrive.

When they dismounted in the Qulba meadow behind the Bagh-i-Maidan, Samarkandis came pouncing in big numbers. The attack was unexpected for Babur’s men. Before they could settle even a bit and breathe before brandishing their swords, Ali Quli’s son had been unhorsed and dragged into the fort. This skirmish was brisk and did not last for long. Perhaps it was an attempt by the Samarkandis to show Babur his place.

But Babur always lived with the desire to conquer Samarkand. He was not going to give up so easily. He took some time. Stayed at peace for some days and made a move to the top of Qulba at the rear side of Kohik. This move of Babur’s made Samarkandis believe that he had given up and it was a retreat. Presuming their success, Samarkandi soldiers as well as the civilians, came out of the grand Turquoise Gate, expressing delight. They came too far, arching and dancing in joy. They crossed the Shaikh Zada’s Gate, reached Mīrzā’s bridge and attempted to cross the Zarafshan River.

Babur ordered the worst possible assault. His tactic and strategy of disillusioning the men of Samarkand had worked. They were attacked from both ends and the men of Samarkand could never recover. They were beaten badly.

That day (sometime in August–September of AD 1497) was indeed remarkable in Babur’s life, for he had conquered it merely at the age of fifteen.

Babur’s men committed many atrocities on the enemies. The best begs and bravest Samarkandis were unhorsed and brought in. Of all those captured, one was Muhammad Miskin, son of Hafiz Duldai (he once guarded the Gate of Umar Shaikh Mīrzā) whose index finger had been chopped as punishment for rebellion. Most of the captured soldiers were known to Babur, but they faced his hostility in their respective merits. Many traders, and artisans (tunic weavers, etc.) were brought in and tortured before being finally put to death as a punishment for the killing foot soldiers at the Lover’s Cave. They resisted while being taken in, cried aloud but no pleading touched Babur’s heart. Perhaps he was hell-bent on exacting